

Political Parties

Social Science — Civics • Chapter 4 • Chapter Summary & Study Guide for Daksh

Almost everyone — even those who say 'all parties are bad' — has some opinion about political parties. Yet most people don't realise that **without political parties, modern democracy cannot work**. This chapter explains what parties are, the main party systems in the world, India's national and regional parties, the challenges they face, and how reforms can help.

What are political parties? Why do they matter?

A **political party** is a group of people who come together to contest elections and hold power in government. Three components:

- **Leaders** — who direct the party, organise campaigns, become candidates.
- **Active members** — workers, organisers, ideologues.
- **Followers / supporters** — voters and sympathisers.

Why we need them — five core functions of political parties:

- **Contest elections** by putting up candidates.
- Put forward different **policies and programmes**; voters choose from these.
- Form and run **government** when in majority; play role of **opposition** when not.
- Shape **public opinion** through debates, campaigns, media, social movements.
- Provide access to government machinery and welfare schemes for ordinary people.

Party systems in different countries

- **One-party system** — only one party rules; no genuine elections (China). Not democratic.
- **Two-party system** — power alternates between two big parties (USA: Democrats vs Republicans; UK: Labour vs Conservative).
- **Multi-party system** — several parties compete, often forming coalitions. India is multi-party. **Coalition** = alliance of parties to form government.

India's national parties

Election Commission classifies parties as '**national**' or '**state**' (regional). A **national party** has secured at least 6% votes in an Lok Sabha or Assembly election in four states AND won at least 4 Lok Sabha seats; or won 2% LS seats from at least three different states.

Major national parties include: **Indian National Congress (INC)**, **Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)**, **Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP)**, **Communist Party of India (CPI)**, **Communist Party of India (Marxist) — CPI(M)**, **National People's Party (NPP)**, **All India Trinamool Congress (AITC)** and **Nationalist Congress Party (NCP)** — though the exact list changes when the EC reviews status.

Regional / state parties

A **state party** meets vote-share/seat criteria in its own state. Examples:

- **Tamil Nadu** — DMK, AIADMK.
- **Andhra/Telangana** — TDP, YSR Congress, BRS.
- **Punjab** — Shiromani Akali Dal.
- **Maharashtra** — Shiv Sena, NCP.
- **Bihar/UP** — Samajwadi Party, Rashtriya Janata Dal, Janata Dal (United).
- **Odisha** — Biju Janata Dal.
- **Jammu & Kashmir** — National Conference, PDP.

Regional parties have made Indian politics more representative and federal. Most central governments since 1989 have been **coalitions** needing regional party support.

Challenges and reforms

Indian political parties face four major challenges:

- **Lack of internal democracy** — top leadership decides everything; few internal elections; younger members can't rise without 'connection'.
- **Dynastic succession** — top posts get passed within a single family.
- **Money and muscle power** — campaigns increasingly need big money and 'goons'; rich and powerful dominate.
- **Lack of meaningful choice** — many parties' policies have converged; voters often see them as 'all same'.

Reforms:

- **Anti-defection law** — to stop elected MLAs/MPs from changing parties for office or money.
- **Mandatory affidavits** — candidates must declare assets and criminal cases.
- **State funding** of elections being debated.
- **EC orders** for internal elections and audits.
- **Citizens' pressure** through media, RTI, civil society — the strongest reformer.

★ MUST-REMEMBER POINTS

- 5 functions of parties: contest elections; offer policies; form government/opposition; shape opinion; access welfare.
- Three party systems: one-party (China), two-party (USA, UK), multi-party (India).
- National party criteria: 6% votes + 4 LS seats from 4 states; OR 2% LS seats from 3 states.
- Major national parties (illustrative): INC, BJP, BSP, CPI, CPI(M), AITC, NCP, NPP.
- Coalition era in India from 1989 — regional parties became kingmakers.
- 4 challenges: internal democracy, dynasty, money/muscle, lack of choice.
- Anti-defection law; affidavits on assets/criminal cases; EC pressure are key reforms.

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